

The gala is a game with turns

Premise

The Meridian Museum unveils Treasures of the World. Billionaire donor Grant Larceny is found poisoned in the Donor Salon. One attending core guest secretly becomes the murderer by animal draw. The facilitator may play without knowing their identity.

What guests actually do

- Act I: introduce themselves, follow three printed social tasks and find museum clues.
- Act II: two seated hearings. Everyone answers one motive question and one whereabouts question using prepared words.
- Act III: each guest submits one assigned evidence card; every card and prepared response is read to the room. Then discuss in pairs and vote.
- Finale: lock all ballots before opening the separate sealed finale envelope. The murderer identifies themselves and reads the confession.
- Improvising is optional. Reading the script is a complete way to play. No essential fact depends on a scavenger find or an absent optional guest.

Run of show

6:00–6:20	Arrival, animal slip and packet; informal introductions
6:20–6:55	Act I: social tasks and scavenger discoveries
6:55–7:05	Buffet; take numbered places at the long table
7:05–7:10	Death announcement, animal draw, F1–F2 read aloud
7:10–7:30	Hearing 1: Motive, one answer per guest
7:30–7:55	Read F3–F4; Hearing 2: Whereabouts
7:55–8:00	Read F5; privately select and collect one evidence card each
8:00–8:20	Hearing 3: Evidence, card plus reply for every guest
8:20–8:35	Guided pair discussion and short challenges
8:35–8:45	Private ballots, collected and locked
8:45–9:05	Tally, optional accusations, sealed finale confession
9:05–9:30	Awards, dessert, debrief

Keep turns short

Aim for 30 seconds for the question and answer, 40 seconds for evidence. Thirty guests need about 15–20 minutes per hearing. With fewer guests, use spare time for discussion. Pause eating while a statement is read.

Arrival and the animal draw

Before play

- Use the attendance roster: mark every attending character ID. Seat guests in ascending ID order, skipping absent IDs.
- Give core guests one slip from Player Bowl A, and optional guests one from the Optional Bowl. Each keeps the slip tucked privately in their packet; memory is not the only safeguard.
- No guest shares their animal. Remove unused Player Bowl A animals from identical Murderer Bowl B before the draw. Optional animals never enter Bowl B.
- At 7:05, shuffle and draw from Bowl B out of view of faces. Announce the animal twice; display the animal word only. Never ask who has it. Keep this slip until the finale.
- After selection, a late arrival is innocent: give them an unused player animal already removed from Bowl B. Never redraw. Optional late arrivals use their separate bowl.

Read aloud at the death

Grant Larceny has been found dead in the Donor Salon. His private cordial was poisoned. Keep a neutral face. If your animal is [ANIMAL], privately use the ANIMAL CALLED answers. Everyone else uses ANIMAL NOT CALLED. Do not tell us your animal. We will ask prepared questions in three hearings. Read only the words inside the answer box; you do not have to invent a story.

Release 1

Read F1 and F2 to the whole room and display them. The window is fictional 6:40–6:49, not a reconstruction of guests' real movements.

The three hearing procedure

Same procedure every hearing

- Give everyone the shared Questions & Notes page. Start with the lowest attending ID.
- The guest immediately before the respondent in seating order reads the shared question, including the respondent's name. For the first turn, the last seated guest asks.
- The respondent reads the answer from the named hearing page. Motive is one common answer; whereabouts and evidence have animal-result alternatives. Read one answer only.
- Tick that ID on the hearing roster. Move to the next occupied seat. No choosing whom to skip, no repeated turns, no dependence on a questioner being present.
- Guests may perform their voice, but may not add factual alibis, events, objects or witnesses. The murderer may deflect within their printed cover story.
- If someone cannot read or would rather pass, let a neighbour read the selected speech box quietly indicated by the guest. Do not inspect their other branch.

At the end of each hearing

Ask: What did we learn? Which accounts need checking? Allow two minutes of comments, then name the next page and release. If conversation stalls, read the shared question again and continue the roster.

Evidence cannot be optional

Collect before Hearing 3

- Release F5. Guests open their EVIDENCE envelopes, then quietly choose the evidence letter printed on their Hearing 3 page for their animal result. Keep the other card hidden.
- Collect exactly one card per attending guest with character ID/name visible. Count against the attendance roster. Missing card: ask that guest privately to submit their assigned letter. Do not let anyone choose the less suspicious card.
- Guest checks the assigned letter privately, not the facilitator. If uncertain, the guest matches their kept animal slip with the announced animal and follows that line.
- Do not start Hearing 3 until every attending ID has one card. Return each submitted card to its owner for the reading, then place it face up on the Evidence Table.
- Each owner reads the entire submitted card and then their selected prepared response. Everybody hears the evidence; no crowded table or quiet guest can conceal it.

Why the evidence works

Innocent records verify continuous presence elsewhere; the murderer's record contradicts their cover during the poison window. Witnesses are different stationed staff, independent of attendance. Automated logs alone are not continuous alibis. The salon attendant assumed a spill cleanup; investigators recognized the vial's significance after toxicology. Correct a wrong submitted letter privately before voting.

Discussion, votes and the finale

Pair discussion / 8:20

With a neighbour, name a suspect, a motive, their claimed location and the specific card that supports or contradicts that location. Write the four points on your notes page. Compare with another pair. Optional question: Does that evidence place the suspect at the glass during 6:40–6:49, or merely show an earlier grievance?

Challenges

Take at most three short challenges. The accused repeats their printed whereabouts or evidence answer. No newly invented facts. If nobody volunteers, ask the room which card conflicts with its owner's account.

Lock the ending

- Everyone submits a private ballot. Collect all ballots before any finale envelope opens. Tally using the attendance roster; no changes after collection.
- For top-three ranking, include every positive-vote suspect tied at the third-place cutoff. If fewer than three names receive votes, only those names count. Zero-vote guests do not enter by tie.
- You may announce the qualifying most-accused names (including cutoff ties) and invite brief accusations. Do not call for innocent/murderer final statements at this stage.
- Ask the guest holding the announced murderer animal to identify themselves. That guest opens only their separate FINALE envelope and reads the confession. All other finale envelopes remain closed.
- The top-three ranking determines Escaped Justice; ballots naming the actual murderer with the contradiction and motive qualify for Master Sleuth. Resolve equal reasoning awards by a shared prize, not by who spoke first.

Preparation and blind assembly

One week before

- Assign all 15 core roles first. Send each guest only their introduction PDF/PNG and invitation.
- Set the address to 1537 S 74th East Ave, Tulsa, OK 74112. Real room labels are staging labels, not claims about the house.
- Print the attendance/hearing roster, shared question pages, ballots, display signs and placards.
- Print private files face down at actual size, single-sided. Each guest gets four play pages, a sealed EVIDENCE envelope containing both A/B cards and a separately sealed FINALE page. Label by ID and name.
- The finale envelope stays at the guest's place closed until after ballots. Do not put the confession loose behind Hearing 3.
- Cut A/B cards along dashed borders; both same-name cards go together. Prepare matching 15-animal A and B sets plus disjoint optional animals.
- Hide discoveries 1-16 by the placement map. Keep F1-F5 together sorted by number; releases are F1-F2, then F3-F4, then F5.

Host-blind safeguard

Open-freely documents contain the whole procedure and neutral roster, not the branch letters or solution. Use the separate assembly map; cover exposed print pages. A playing host never needs to choose which evidence branch is correct.

Act I / Hide discoveries 1–8

1	Dalmo office / Donor Salon	Inside or beneath a folder
2	Viv office / Registrar	Behind a binder or clipboard
3	Bathroom / Patron Lounge	Near the mirror or folded hand towel
4	Media room / Archives	Inside a magazine or program
5	Laundry / Conservation Lab	Beside cleaning or craft supplies
6	Dalmo office / Donor Salon	Under a legal-size envelope
7	Living room / Grand Gallery	Inside an exhibition catalogue
8	Living room / Grand Gallery	Behind a frame or display card

Act I / Hide discoveries 9–16

9	Dining room / Founders Hall	Under an education-program brochure
10	Dalmo office / Donor Salon	Near the room sign or faux security note
11	Media room / Archives	Inside an old-looking notebook
12	Living room / Grand Gallery	Beside an art label or sketch
13	Laundry / Conservation Lab	Under a condition-report clipboard
14	Guest bedroom / Silk Road Gallery	Attached to or inside a prop crate/box
15	Media room / Archives	Near the TV/projector/lighting controls
16	Kitchen / Sculpture Court	Near the buffet/service area

Attendance and cast

01	Artie Ficial	Executive Director of the Meridian Museum
02	Claire O’Scurio	Chief Curator of World Cultures
03	Hugh Bidder	International Art Dealer & Collector Liaison
04	Monet Bags	Chief Financial Officer of the Meridian Museum
05	Chip Patina	Chief Conservator
06	Dada DiCapo	Performance Artist & Cultural Celebrity
07	Vincent Van Faux	Celebrated Contemporary Painter
08	Sue Venir	Cultural Property Attorney
09	Dr. Art E. Fact	Professor of Art History & Provenance Scholar
10	Tess Tament	Philanthropist & Heir to the Larceny Family Fortune
11	Barb Dwyer	Director of Museum Security & Former Art-Crimes Investigator
12	Paige Turner	Investigative Arts Journalist
13	Frank Lloyd Wrong	Exhibition Architect & Designer
14	Mona Lott	International Cultural Heritage Envoy
15	Elon Mosaic	Tech Founder, Collector & Museum Patron

Additional guests

16	Anya Tique	Founding Curator Emerita
17	Saul D. Bid	Chairman of Gavel & Rowe Auction House
18	Elle Loominate	Textile Artist & Designer
19	Reed DeLabel	Doctoral Fellow in Art History
20	Al Baster	Sculptor & Public-Art Star
21	Ella Gance	Collector, Style Patron & Society Fixture
22	Drew Conclusions	Art Critic & Cultural Podcaster
23	Brie DeVivre	Head Caterer & Hospitality Director
24	Cary Crates	Senior Art Handler & Installation Specialist
25	Anne E. Dote	Director of Education & Docent Programs
26	Faye Stop	Gala Photographer & Editorial Portraitist
27	Robin Banks	Cultural Restitution Activist & Nonprofit Organizer
28	Penny Pincher	Eccentric Private Collector
29	Justin Tyme	Tulsa Arts Columnist & Local Historian
30	Minnie Malist	Gala Event Designer & Creative Producer